“Śrī Caitanya-caritāmṛta”

Antya-līlā

Chapter 9

The Deliverance of Gopīnātha Paṭṭanāyaka

(translated from the Bengali for this edition)

1 By the flood of love of Śrī Caitanya’s countless blessed associates, the desert of unfortunate people’s hearts was forever turned into a well-watered land.

2 Glory, glory to Śrī Kṛṣṇa Caitanya, the merciful! Glory, glory to Nityānanda, whose heart is full of compassion!

3 Glory to Advaitācārya — glory, glory to the merciful one! Glory to all the devotees of Gaura, who are full of *rasa*!

4 In this way Mahāprabhu lived in Nīlācala with His devotees, in the joy of love for Kṛṣṇa.

5 Within and without surged the waves of separation from Kṛṣṇa; the Lord’s mind and body were agitated by various *bhāvas* (states of love).

6 By day there was dancing and *kīrtana* and the sight of Jagannātha; by night He relished *rasa* with Rāya and Svarūpa.

7 People of the three worlds came to see Him, and whoever saw Him gained the treasure of love for Kṛṣṇa.

8 In human guise came *devas*, *gandharvas* and *kinnaras*, and all the Daityas and serpents of the seven nether worlds.

9 All the people who dwell on the seven *dvīpas* (islands) and in the nine *khaṇḍas* (regions) came in various guises to see the Lord.

10 Sages such as Prahlāda, Bali, Vyāsa and Śuka came, and seeing the Lord, they lost consciousness in love.

11 Outside, the people cried aloud when they could not see Him; then the Lord would come out and say, “Say ‘Kṛṣṇa’!”

12 At the sight of the Lord all the people floated in love. In this way the Lord’s days and nights passed.

13 One day people came and reported to the Lord, “The Baḍa Jānā, the eldest prince, has raised Gopīnātha onto the *cāṅga* (the execution platform).

14 They have set swords beneath it and will throw him down onto them from above. Only if You, Lord, protect him will he be saved.

15 Bhavānanda Rāya and his whole family are Your servants. His son is Your servant, and it is fitting that You protect him.”

16 The Lord said, “Why is the king punishing him?” Then the people told Him the whole story.

17 “Gopīnātha Paṭṭanāyaka, Rāmānanda’s brother, has always been a keeper of the king’s property (*rāja-viṣayī*).

18 His charge was Mālajāṭhyā Daṇḍapāṭa. He collected the revenue there and delivered it to the king’s court.

19 Two lakhs of *kāhanas* (a *kāhana* is 1,280 cowries) fell due from him, and the king demanded the two lakhs of *kāhanas* of cowries.

20 He said, ‘I have no ready wealth that I could give at once. Little by little, by selling and buying, I will make good the sum.

21 I have ten or twelve horses — take them at a fair valuation.’ Saying this, he led the horses to the king’s gate.

22 One prince knew well the value of horses, and the king sent him there with ministers and friends.

23 That prince set the value low, and Gopīnātha grew angry when he heard the price.

24 That prince had a habit: he would turn his neck and, with his face upward, look here and there again and again.

25 Mocking him, Gopīnātha spoke proud words; the king favoured him, so he felt no fear.

26 ‘My horse raises its neck, but it does not look upward. So it is not right to set its price low.’

27 Hearing this, the prince grew angry. He went to the king and slandered Gopīnātha at length:

28 ‘This man will not pay the money; he goes about making excuses. Give the order, and I will raise him onto the *cāṅga* and get the money.’

29 The king said, ‘Go and do whatever is best. By whatever means I may get the money, use that means.’

30 The prince came and raised him onto the *cāṅga*, and to throw him onto the swords, he set swords beneath it.”

31 Hearing this, the Lord spoke with a show of affectionate anger: “He will not pay the king’s money — what fault is that of the king’s?

32 He collects the king’s revenue and consumes it without any fear of the king; he squanders it in various ways, giving it to harlots and dancers.

33 Let one who is clever do the king’s service: when he has paid off the king’s dues, let him spend what is left to him.”

34 Just then another man came running: “Vāṇīnātha and the others have been bound and taken away with their families!”

35 The Lord said, “The king himself will take the money that stands on the account. I am a detached *sannyāsī* — what can I do in this?”

36 Then Svarūpa and the other devotees of the Lord all made an entreaty at His feet:

37 “The family of Rāmānanda Rāya are all Your servants. Such indifference is not fitting for You.”

38 Hearing this, Mahāprabhu spoke angrily: “So you all order Me to go to the king’s court!

39 This is what you all think: that I should go to the king, spread out the end of My cloth and beg the money from him.

40 A *sannyāsī brāhmaṇa* is fit to receive five *gaṇḍās* (twenty cowries). Even if I begged, why would anyone give two lakhs of *kāhanas*?”

41 Just then another man came running: “They are throwing Gopīnātha down onto the swords!”

42 Hearing this, the Lord’s associates entreated Him, but the Lord said, “I am a beggar; nothing can be done by Me.

43 So if you all have it in mind to save him, go together to the feet of Jagannātha.

44 Jagannātha is the Lord, *Īśvara*, in whose hands all things lie. He is able to do, not to do, and to do otherwise.”

45 While Mahāprabhu was saying this, Haricandana Pātra went and spoke to the king:

46 “Gopīnātha Paṭṭanāyaka is your servant, and to put a servant to death is not proper conduct.

47 Moreover, money is still owed by him. What gain is there in taking his life? It would only be the loss of your own wealth.

48 Take the horses at their proper value; whatever remains he will pay little by little. Why take his life needlessly?”

49 The king said, “I know nothing of this. Why should I take his life? It is his money I want.

50 Go there and settle everything, so that the money comes in and his life is spared.”

51 Then Haricandana came and told the Jānā, and Gopīnātha was quickly brought down from the *cāṅga*.

52 “The king demands the money,” Haricandana said, and asked him how he would pay. Gopīnātha replied, “Take the horses at their proper value.

53 The rest I will pay little by little, whatever I can. If you take my life without inquiry, what can I say?”

54 Then they valued the horses properly and took them all, and, binding him to pay the rest of the money by a fixed date, they sent him home.

55 Meanwhile the Lord asked that man, “What was Vāṇīnātha doing when they bound him and took him away?”

56 He said, “Vāṇīnātha was fearlessly chanting the name of Kṛṣṇa, saying ‘Hare Kṛṣṇa, Hare Kṛṣṇa’ without rest.

57 To keep count, he marked the names on the fingers of both hands, and whenever a thousand or so were complete, he scratched a line on his body.”

58 Hearing this, Mahāprabhu was supremely joyful. Who can understand the design of Gaura’s mercy?

59 At that time Kāśī Miśra came to the Lord, and the Lord spoke to him with some anxiety:

60 “I cannot stay here; I shall go to Ālālanātha. There are many disturbances here, and I find no peace.

61 The family of Bhavānanda Rāya is in the king’s service, and in various ways they spend the king’s money.

62 What fault is the king’s? The king wants his own money. They will not give the money, and then they report their punishment to Me.

63 When the king had Gopīnātha raised onto the *cāṅga*, people came four times to tell Me.

64 I am a mendicant *sannyāsī* who lives in solitude, yet they come and pain Me by telling Me their own troubles.

65 Today Jagannātha has protected him; but tomorrow who will protect him if he does not pay the king's money?

66 Hearing the affairs of worldly men disturbs My mind, and so I have no reason to stay here."

67 Clasping the Lord's feet, Kāśī Miśra said, "Why do You let this matter trouble Your mind?

68 You are a detached *sannyāsī* — what connection have You with anyone? One who worships You for worldly ends is blind to true knowledge.

69 The fruit of worshipping You is the treasure of love for You. One who worships You for the sake of worldly things is a fool.

70 For Your sake Rāmānanda gave up his governorship; for Your sake Sanātana abandoned his worldly position.

71 For Your sake Raghunātha gave up everything, and here his father sent him wealth.

72 But the mercy of Your feet has come to him: he begs his food at the alms-house and does not touch that wealth.

73 The noble Gopīnātha, Rāmānanda's brother, has no wish for worldly gain from You.

74 Seeing his distress, his servants and others told You of it, for he has no shelter but You (*ananya-śaraṇa*).

75 He is a pure devotee who worships You for Your own sake; in his own happiness and distress he himself bears his share.

76 He longs for Your mercy and worships You constantly; soon he attains Your feet.

77 ‘Therefore one who lives earnestly awaiting Your mercy, enduring the fruits of his own deeds and offering You obeisance with heart, words and body, is an heir to the position of liberation.’ (Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam, 10.14.8)

78 Stay settled here. Why should You go to Ālālanātha? No one will make You listen to the talk of worldly men.

79 If You have a mind to protect him, He who protected him today will protect him still.”

80 Saying this, Kāśī Miśra went to his own residence, and at midday Pratāparudra came to his house.

81 Pratāparudra kept one rule for as long as he stayed in Śrī Puruṣottama:

82 every day he would come and massage Miśra’s feet, and hear how the service of Jagannātha was being carried out in all its order and splendor (*bhiyāna*).

83 When the king began pressing Miśra’s feet, Miśra told him something in a roundabout way:

84 “Your Majesty, hear one more strange piece of news: Mahāprabhu is going to leave the holy place (*kṣetra*) for Ālālanātha!”

85 Hearing this, the king became sorrowful and asked the reason. Then Miśra told him the whole story:

86 “Gopīnātha Paṭṭanāyaka was raised onto the *cāṅga*, and his servant came and told the Lord.

87 Hearing this, Mahāprabhu’s mind was agitated, and in anger He rebuked Gopīnātha severely:

88 ‘He handles the king’s affairs without controlling his senses, and spends the king’s wealth in all sorts of wrong ways.

89 The king’s wealth weighs more than a brāhmaṇa’s property; one who steals it to enjoy it is a great sinner.

90 He lives on the king’s salary and steals besides; by the judgment of scripture he deserves the king’s punishment.

91 The king asks only for his own money and does not punish him. The king is most righteous; this man is a sinful cheat!

92 He does not pay the king’s money, and he cries out loudly to Me (*phukāre*). Who here can bear such great distress?

93 I shall go to Ālālanātha and stay there free from care; I will not hear the news of worldly men, good or bad.’”

94 Hearing this, the king felt pain in his heart and said, “I give up all the money, if only the Lord will stay here.

95 If I can have the Lord’s *darśana* for even a moment, gaining millions of *cintāmaṇi* gems is not its equal.

96 What paltry thing are these two lakh *kāhanas*? I offer up my life and my kingdom at the Lord's feet (*nirmañchana*)."

97 Miśra said, "It is not the Lord's wish that you give up the money. They are suffering, and that He cannot bear."

98 The king said, "I mean him no pain. Raising him onto the *cāṅga*, throwing him onto the swords — I knew nothing of it.

99 He mocked Puruṣottama Jānā, and that Jānā only gave him a false scare.

100 Go and do all you can to keep the Lord here. Here and now I release him from all the money."

101 Miśra said, "Your giving up the money is not what the Lord has in mind. If you give it up, the Lord may perhaps be pained."

102 The king said, "I shall give up the money, but do not tell Him that. Let Him know only this: they are naturally dear to me.

103 Bhavānanda Rāya is worthy of my honor and my pride (*pūjya-garvita*), and I naturally feel affection for his sons."

104 Saying this, the king offered obeisance to Miśra and went home. The Baḍa Jānā called Gopīnātha and brought him.

105 The king said, "I release you from all the money, and I give you that same Mālajāṭhyā Daṇḍapāṭa again.

106 Do not consume the king's wealth like this again. From today I give you double salary."

107 Saying this, he dressed him in silk cloth (*netadhaṭī*): “Take the Lord’s permission and go; you have your leave.”

108 Leave aside the Lord’s mercy in the supreme goal of life (*paramārtha*): its fruits are unlimited — who can tell them?

109 This fruit of royal wealth came from a mere semblance (*ābhāsa*) of His mercy! No one can even conceive of its reckoning!

110 On one hand, he was raised onto the *cāṅga* to lose his wealth and life! On the other, everything was forgiven, and a kingdom and more were bestowed on him!

111 On one hand, all he owned was to be sold off, and still the money could not be paid! On the other, a double salary, and he is dressed in silk!

112 The Lord had no wish that his money be remitted, that his salary be doubled, or that he be given his post again.

113 Still, his servant came and made his petition, and Mahāprabhu’s mind was disturbed by it.

114 The Lord had no inclination to give worldly happiness; yet even by the power of a mere petition such fruit was borne.

115 Who can describe the wonderful nature of Gaura? Even Brahmā, Śiva and the others cannot fathom His inner intent.

116 Meanwhile Kāśī Miśra came to the Lord’s feet and reported all that the king had done.

117 The Lord said, “Kāśī Miśra, what have you done? Have you made Me accept a gift from the king (*rāja-pratigraha*)?”

118 Miśra said, “Lord, hear the king’s words. Without any guile the king made this request:

119 ‘Let the Lord not think that the king has given up two lakh *kāhanas* of money for His sake.

120 All of Bhavānanda’s sons are most dear to me; I regard them all as my own self.

121 So I give them posts here and there. They eat, drink, plunder and give away, and I do not look into it.

122 In Rājamahendrī I made Rāmānanda Rāya governor (*rājā*). Whatever he consumed and whatever he gave away, no account was asked of him.

123 In the same way, while handling the king’s business, Gopīnātha goes on consuming two to four lakh *kāhanas*.

124 He pays some and does not pay some, and I do not look into it. This time he came to grief through his ill will with the Jānā.

125 I did not know that the Jānā had gone so far. I regard all of Bhavānanda’s sons as my own self.

126 Let Him not consider that I am giving up the money for His sake (*māt*, “not”): my love for them is natural.’”

127 Hearing of the king’s humility, the Lord was pleased. Just then Bhavānanda Rāya arrived there.

128 He came with his five sons and fell at the Lord’s feet. The Lord raised him up and embraced him.

129 Rāmānanda Rāya and all the others met the Lord. Then Bhavānanda Rāya began to speak:

130 “This whole family of mine are Your servants. Saving us in this danger, Lord, You have bought us again for a price (*nilā mūla*).

131 Now You have shown Your affection for Your devotees, as long ago You delivered the five Pāṇḍavas from danger.”

132 Gopīnātha, the silk cloth on his head, fell at the Lord’s feet and told the whole story of the king’s kindness:

133 “He remitted the money I owed and doubled my salary; he gave me my post again and dressed me in silk.

134 On one hand, that peril of death on top of the *cāṅga*! On the other, silk cloth again — all this is Your grace!

135 On the *cāṅga* I meditated on Your feet, and by the power of remembering Your feet I obtained this fruit.

136 Seeing all this happen to me, people are amazed; they sing and praise the glory of Your mercy.

137 But this is not the chief fruit of remembering You. It is only a semblance of fruit (*phalābhāsa*), for worldly things are fickle.

138 You made Rāmānanda Rāya and Vāṇīnātha free from worldly affairs. On me there is not that mercy by which this comes about!

139 Show me pure mercy, Gosāñi: take away my worldly affairs. I have grown weary of them (*nirviṇṇa*); worldly affairs are not for me.”

140 The Lord said, “If all five of you become *sannyāsīs*, who will maintain your large household?

141 Whether you manage great worldly affairs or live detached and indifferent to the world, birth after birth you five are My own servants.

142 But keep one order of Mine: do not spend any of the king’s principal (*mūla-dhana*).

143 After paying the king his principal, spend whatever profit remains on various religious and pious works.

144 Do not spend on sinful things, by which both worlds are lost.” Saying this, He gave them all leave to go.

145 I have told of the Lord’s *kṛpā-vivarta* — a seeming mercy — in the house of Bhavānanda Rāya, in which His quality of affection for His devotees was revealed.

146 When He embraced them all and gave them leave, all the devotees rose and went away, calling out the name of Hari.

147 Seeing the Lord’s mercy, everyone was amazed; they could not understand the Lord’s conduct.

148 When they had all entreated Him to show mercy, the Lord had said, “Nothing will be done by Me.”

149 He spoke only censure of Gopīnātha and His own weariness with the world (*nirveda*); no one will understand the secret of this.

150 He did not entreat Kāśī Miśra, nor did He entreat the king; yet without any effort He gave all this fruit.

151 This conduct of Śrī Caitanya is supremely deep. Only he understands it whose mind is steady (*dhīra*) at His feet.

152 Whoever hears this display of the Lord’s affection attains loving devotion, and his dangers are destroyed.

153 Praying at the feet of Śrī Rūpa and Śrī Raghunātha, I, Kṛṣṇadāsa, narrate the *Caitanya-caritāmṛta*.